prayers that Kishan Singh objected to. He objected to the way in which the Khalsa schools stooped in supplication to the British Empire.

The D.A.V School in Lahore had no such pretensions. Founded in 1885 on Arya Samaji principles under the tutelage of Lala Lajpat Rai, it held no such fears for Kishan Singh, which was just as well, because by the time that Bhagat Singh entered Class IX, he was already joining processions and collecting foreign clothes and setting them alight in a bonfire. He had learnt to support the Gandhian non-cooperation movement slogan of '*Hindu-Muslim Ekta Zindabad / Gandhi Ki Jai*' [5] ('Long Live the Unity of Hindus and Muslims as One / and Long Live Gandhi'). Already, when on 20 February 1921, during the time when Sikhs were struggling to assume democratic control over their historic places of worship (gurudwaras) from government-appointed priests (mahants), hundreds of pilgrims at Nankana Sahib Gurudwara in Sheikhpura District were shot down by them, hacked to pieces and burnt with kerosene. Bhagat Singh went out of his way to visit the site on his way to his village in Banga. He was only fourteen years old then and yet he even attended a conference there on 5 March 1921. Indeed, as Professor Malwinder Jit Warraich writes, 'his visit to Nankana Sahib in the wake of the gruesome killing was in line with his visit to Jallianwala Bagh on 14 April 1919', [6] a day after the Amritsar Massacre, when he would have been only twelve.

If the decision to send a Sikh boy into the DAV College was historic, Bhagat Singh's entry six years later in 1923 into the National College in Lahore was momentous, because it was affiliated with the Punjab Quami Vidyapith. The 'Vidyapith' schools were based on a new model of education, established in different parts of the country, from as far afield as Calcutta, Patna, Benares, Aligarh and Delhi as well as Lahore. They emphasized curricula that prioritized the learning of history, culture, tradition and philosophy and aimed to inculcate patriotic sentiments in the youth in a way that government-aided institutions did not do. The Lahore 'Vidyapith' school was founded and managed by Lala Lajpat Rai and Bhai Parmanand. It successfully managed to bring into its curriculum the principle of 'swadeshi'. As Lala Lajpat Rai himself explained, he aimed for